Lanier Falcons Navigate Leadership Changes

By Caleb James

The Lanier Falcons are entering the 2026-27 academic year with a society full of new faces and a chance to rebuild a society that was getting smaller by the year.

The Center for Leadership Development became involved with Lanier after several semesters of attempts to help the society grow from within. The CLD helped bring in a new group of students to lead Lanier after its membership had steadily declined.

Aaron Burk, CLD Director, said the decision to step in was not made quickly.

Burk said the CLD had been working with Lanier for at least three semesters before bringing in new leadership from the outside. A small number of members had been trying to keep the society going from within but were unable to bring in enough students to build the society successfully.

Burk compared the situation to having two buses. Buses all have wheels, seats and lights, but the contents of the bus greatly vary. Societies have similar structures, he said, but each one has its own culture, traditions and identity.

“We aren’t trying to just eliminate the membership necessarily,” Burk said. “We definitely are not trying to make it something it isn’t.”

Instead, the CLD wanted to give Lanier another chance to become an active society.

The process began by finding students who were willing to take responsibility for rebuilding the group. Burk said the CLD typically looks for around seven or eight people to form a new leadership core.

Those students are given the society’s founding documents and are encouraged to learn about its history and mission.

Connor Allen, a senior biblical studies major, became involved during the spring semester after Burk approached him about Lanier. At the time, Allen was serving as the Inter Society Council director where he worked with all societies and their leadership.

Burk told Allen that Lanier was at a point where it needed a revitalization. If nothing changed, Allen said, Lanier could have been down to only two members the next year.

“I just knew that it was something that could be saved,” Allen said.

Allen assembled a 10-member leadership team of students from other societies to begin rebuilding Lanier.

Allen said his goal is to bring Lanier back to what it was about 10 years ago, when the society was more highly regarded across campus and had a better reputation, especially in sports.

He mentioned building a stronger brotherhood within the society and keeping its Christian identity at the center.

Lanier's theme is based on Colossians 3:1: "Therefore, if you have been raised with Christ, seek the things that are above, where Christ is, seated at the right hand of God" (Colossians 3:1, ESV). Its Greek letters are Sigma Tau Alpha, and its motto is "Seeking things above," Allen said.

Allen said the transition has received support from some existing Lanier members, but Abishai Cherian, who joined Lanier his freshman year and even served as president for a semester, said he believes the process should have involved more input from those already in the society.

"I think that it was handled poorly," Cherian said. "There was no synergy with the existing members."

Cherian later explained that the new group has preserved Lanier's outward identity but believes other parts of the society have significantly changed.

"I think they're keeping core attributes, but not core values," Cherian said.

This is likely due to the fact that Burk said existing members were not given the opportunity to be involved in choosing the new leadership, because members who were leaving or graduating should not be the ones deciding who would lead the society going forward.

This meant that Lanier had to make some massive acquisitions at Rush this semester. Burk stated that Lanier needed at least 12 to 15 freshmen to become an active and successful society again; Allen later confirmed that same number.

Allen also said that the incoming freshman class is especially important for Lanier because they are ultimately the ones who will make Lanier grow continually.

For Cherian, however, a larger number of members means significant change, especially after Lanier had an extremely successful Rush, adding over 40 new freshmen.

Cherian said he is happy to see the new group bring more students to society, but he believes it changes the identity of the society.

"I'm happy for them," Cherian said. "I'm happy that they rushed 40 plus people, but I just don't think that Lanier is going to be Lanier anymore, at least as we know it."

Allen put it bluntly: "This class coming in, it's on them."

The new leadership has already exceeded its original recruitment goal, but the future of Lanier remains uncertain. As the society grows, its new leaders will have to balance rebuilding its membership with preserving the identity and traditions that original members say made Lanier what it was.



From left, Elizabeth Gonzalez, Anna Heinrich, Abbie Paige, Gabriel Gearhart, Evan Wright and Connor Allen pose in front of society booths during a rainy rush party. Photo by Lauren Conn.